behind prison walls as a site to balance solitary forms of punishment with one's own existence against that of a larger social body. Such authors, he claims, consider prison walls as mirrors to reflect not merely on the crimes for which the individuals were convicted but also on the larger contexts for their imprisonment—including the "claustrophobic structures of modern consciousness and capitalism."[38] Lee Bernstein notes that the 1970s were an era of prison reform in which "prisons had become the center of a key ideological fissure shaping American life." He adds, "Incarcerated people during the late 1960s and 1970s hoped that the prison walls that segregated them from the larger world might reveal unseen aspects of U.S. society. Their words crossed the wall, but they also helped many people to rethink the meaning of the walls, and ultimately, the society that produced them."[39] More than a reader of this history, Davis was seen as also having shaped new approaches to such reflective, engaged writings. Dan Berger writes of the 1972 "Tear Down the Walls" Prison Action Conference at the University of California, Berkley, which cited in its circulating materials, "courageous leaders like George Jackson, Angela Davis, Huey Newton, and others [who] have stressed the need … to bring attention to the systematic oppression of the convict class."[40] In each instance, the prison wall is both the looming architecture of an unjust society, extending beyond its physical footprint toward other facets of society, and a site necessary to grasp and address racial and class transformation.

As Davis shaped and shared consciousness around critical advocacy related to prison and division, her life was widely portrayed through dozens of complimentary and competing biographical narratives that fueled public and popular intrigue about the circumstances of her life. While her face and image became emblematic of her life story and the political forces swirling around her case, various interpretations of Davis's life story, including her own writing, were also used as significant fodder for the shaping of her public persona.[41]

Davis's case was a fixture in the national media, including cover stories by *Newsweek, Time*, and *Jet* magazines, all of which used her image but also delivered stories deliberately focused on her upbringing and development as a means of understanding how she became a political radical on her academic trajectory and as if to explain her legal predicament of incarceration as jointly connected to her potential freedom. Davis's own words and writings had been unsuccessfully leveraged against her by the